

AGAINST THE TIDE West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee leads an all-faith Sanhati rally in Kolkata, Jan. 22

MAMATA COUNTERED MODI'S PROJECT RAM BY INVOKING CULTURAL IDENTITY, BANGLA PRIDE AND ASKING FOR "CLASSICAL LANGUAGE" STATUS FOR BENGALI

once again sought to cling to secularism as an answer. So, former party chief Sonia Gandhi prevailed over party colleagues in deciding that the Congress would stay away from the inauguration even as many Congress Working Committee members, including young turk Kanhaiya Kumar, opposed the idea. And he was not alone. If Karnataka deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar, asked, "What's wrong in attending the consecration ceremony?", Himachal Pradesh CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu broke ranks and declared a public holiday to enable employees to participate in the day's events. His cabinet colleague, Vikramaditya Singh, also attended the ceremony as a sign of respect for his late father and ex-CM Virbhadra Singh who had supported the Ram temple movement.

While these leaders feared the 'anti-Hindu' label (the BJP, expectedly, called those who declined the invite so), Rahul has dismissed the existence of any "wave" around Ram. Instead, he hopes to reach out to the people with his construct of justice built on the five pillars of equal participation, women, youth, farmers and workers. However, not many are convinced that this will fetch much electoral dividend. Kumar of CSDS says narratives such as 'Modi is a dictator', 'no rule of law in the country' and 'democracy and Constitution are at risk' do not work with the larger masses. Only a small section understands these arguments, he feels. "People will not vote for the Congress just because Rahul has taken out a yatra or has criticised the Ram temple inauguration as the BJP's political project. It has to offer something more tangible to voters," says Kumar.

That is where the BJP's Hindutva politics is a force-multiplier, for it's not the only driver of its electoral success. This was evident in the recent assembly elections where a blend of Hindutva and welfare handouts helped the saffron party successfully neutralise the Opposition campaign built around the caste census. The demand for the latter is aimed at making a dent in the BJP's OBC vote bank, which was its mainstay in the previous two Lok Sabha elections as well as the many assembly polls.

The saffron party has assiduously nurtured several social blocs, promising them dignity backed by welfare schemes. On occasion, it has also supplemented it with symbolism. The Bharat Ratna to the late Bihar CM and OBC icon Karpoori Thakur is clearly aimed at wooing voters in a state where the BJP is on a sticky wicket after the Nitish Kumar-led Janata Dal (United) dumped them. These social exercises are above and beyond the umbrella matrix the BJP has built, and the Opposition will need a categorical narrative, communicated in what Gupta calls a "transactional language", if it has to crack it. That's clearly lacking in India's Opposition today. ■

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